RESUME NOTES

I. Basic Facts

A. Writing Skills
   - Hiring personnel likely to hold a poorly written resume against the applicant
   - Used as a weed-out tool
   - Should use minimal wording, thus making sure each carefully chosen fact produces a lasting impression on an employer

B. Time Allotted and Length
   - Average time spent on a resume is 10 to 30 seconds
   - Should be one page

C. "Does it Help" Rule
   - When adding information, ask yourself "does it help?"
   - Will the piece of information help get the interview
   - Is it relevant to the position I want
   - Does it solve their problem
   - Is it more important than something else

II. Resume Defined

A. Purpose
   - A resume is a summary of your experiences and skills relevant to the field of work you are entering.
   - It highlights your accomplishments to show a potential employer that you are qualified for the work you want. It is not a biography of everything you have done.
   - Its purpose is to get you an interview.
   - A resume can and should reflect more than just your paid work experience. Include the details of your more important extracurricular, volunteer, and leadership experiences.

B. Tailored Resumes
   - Tailor separate resumes to fit each career field in which you are job searching. You can create slightly different resumes tailored to each job opening.

III. Resume Types:

- Chronological Resume
- Most common
- Objective statement followed by chronological job history, including some highlighted achievements at each position
- Shows progress in a single profession, thus puts emphasis on work experience (may not be the best choice for a college graduate)
- Functional Resume
- Emphasis on abilities instead of work history
- Objective statement followed by list of skills an employer wants with a brief example of the qualifications; employment history follows at the bottom in a brief format
- Chrono-Functional Resume

- Combines the strengths of both resumes
- Objective statement followed by a list of a few key skills followed by an in-depth employment history similar to a chronological resume
- Good for students who have internship experience and career-oriented extracurricular activities

IV. Getting Started

Step 1: Make a list of your various activities over the years

- Include paid work, volunteer positions, extracurricular activities (especially those in which you had a leadership role) and internships.
- Can go as far back as four or five years. Graduating seniors will often have one or two items from high school on their resume if those items stress an important skill.

Step 2: Write a paragraph about each important item in your list.

- "Important items" would include most paid work, internships, extended volunteer activities, and activities in which you had a leadership role.
- Don't worry about the wording of your paragraphs at this point ; “resume language” will come later
- Describe accomplishments as well as duties (provide a skill and its result)
- An example of a duty might be "I maintained ten computers, loading new software and resolving problems as needed," while an example of an accomplishment might be "I created two self-paced PowerPoint presentations to train people in our office on the new company software, and it was so successful that my manager asked me to present it to five other managers in the company."

Note: You will eventually change your wording into "resume language," dropping any "I's" and making your phrases more concise. For now, use whatever language you want.

Step 3: Pick the items that you will highlight or emphasize on your resume.

- Give this some thought. Consider two factors here:
  - What are your greatest strengths, and how can you demonstrate those strengths through your experience? All employers value certain qualities: team player; good communication skills; leadership abilities. In addition, you have particular skills that you consider your strong points, you would generally try to bring those to light, as well.
  - What are the requirements and needs of this particular industry, this particular employer and this particular job?

Here's an example of the needs of an industry and a job:

- Advertising industry - account executive:
- The industry tends to value creativity, high energy, and the ability to work in a hectic, deadline-driven environment.
- The job of account executive demands that you be detail-oriented, good with people and able to handle many projects at once.
- Your task, then, would be to demonstrate those qualities through the activities described on your resume.

Step 4: Create the sections of your resume.

- Section 1: Name and Address
- Put your name in at least 14-point. Recruiters often must look through stacks of resumes in search of a particular one. Make it easy for them to see your name.
- Include both your school address and phone number, as well as the address and phone number where you can be reached during school vacations or after you graduate.
- Include your e-mail address. If you check your e-mail during school vacations, you may want to center the address on your resume in a way that implies it is not just associated with your school address.
- Section 2: Objective
- Objective: An objective is optional, but should be included. If you have worked out a clearly targeted job objective, then definitely include it.
- 1-2 sentences about the job sought and why you would be a valuable part of the team
- Avoid pronouns and flowery language; don't be too general ("a challenging position enabling me to contribute to organizational goals while offering an opportunity for growth and advancement")
- Focus on what you have to offer rather than on what the job can offer you. Employers want to know if you fit their needs, not what you hope to get out of a job.
- Example: "OBJECTIVE: Editorial assistant position in the publishing industry, utilizing my academic background in literature and my three years of experience writing for campus and local newspapers."
- Section 3: Education
- This section always goes first on your resume, as long as you are in school.
- Include major, minor, type of degree, honors distinctions, GPA
- If you are still an undergraduate and applying for an internship, list your high school below your college in this section. Note: Your significant activities from high school can be listed in this section, though many students benefit more from listing those in more detail in their Experience or Activities sections.
- Once you have graduated from college, your education section goes first on your resume from one to three years, depending on such factors as whether your education was relevant to your career field and how impressive your work experience has been in the intervening years. If you have recently received a graduate or professional degree, your education would usually go at the top of your resume.
- As a graduating senior, your GPA should always be mentioned, as long as it is above 3.0. Most recruiters will assume that it is below 3.0 if they do not see it on your resume.
- "Courses studied" or Relevant Coursework" is an optional section. If you have taken courses outside your major that are relevant to the job (or if you simply want to emphasize your academic training relevant to the job or internship), you would definitely benefit from including this section. For example, if you were a Philosophy major trying to find work in the computer industry, and you had taken three courses in the Computer Science department; you would definitely include them in a "Relevant Courses" section.
- Significant honors and awards can be included as a sub-category of your Education section.
- Section 4: Experience
- Don't limit this section to paid work experiences. Employers understand that the most valuable or most challenging experiences often occur in internships, volunteer work or other extracurricular activities.
- Opportunity to show how transferred skills learned in the classroom to the workplace.
- Student Teaching Experience - Include name and location of placements, dates involved, and grade level of assignment. Major responsibilities in teaching area should be emphasized.
- How should you describe your experiences?
- Consult the paragraphs you wrote about each of your jobs or activities: choose from one to eight sentences that encapsulate the skills you used at this job or activity, your duties and your significant accomplishments. (skill and result)

- Include both your duties and your accomplishments.
- Duties tell the employer you can do the job. Accomplishments indicate that you will go above and beyond the call of duty:
- Duties alone can sound bland: "Wrote articles, researched topics, filed documents"?
- When you add your accomplishments and contributions, you set yourself apart from the other applicants: "Researched and wrote weekly Music Notes for local arts newspaper. Created archival database that saved staff several hours of work per week. Chosen from among seven interns to represent newspaper at MusicFest 2001 festival; wrote feature story that ran on front page."
- Use action verbs ("wrote," "managed," "researched," "coached," "planned," etc.).
- Where possible, use keywords.
- Cite numbers to make a point (e.g. number of people supervised; size of event created).
- Be concise; use telegram rather than narrative style.
- Include "buzz" words only if you are sure of their meaning.
- Include employment dates (month and year).
- Section 5: Activities, Volunteer work, Interests
- If you choose to separate your work experience from your extracurricular activities or volunteer work, they can go in a separate section, but they don't have to go in a separate section.
- You do not need to demote these activities to the bottom of your resume. What's left at the bottom of your resume may not get any attention.
- Listing your "interests" or hobbies on a resume is okay, but generally you should not do so at the expense of leaving out other, more important information.
- When should you list your interests?
- When your interests or hobbies are so unusual that they are bound to attract positive attention.
- When your interests or hobbies reflect positively on your job skills. For example, if you are applying for work as a paralegal and you love chess, the recruiter may equate your hobby with analytical abilities.
- Section 6: Skills
- This is an optional section depending on the type of resume written.Computer skills:
- You may wish to list the systems (Macintosh, IBM, UNIX, etc.) and applications (Filemaker Pro, Microsoft Word, PageMaker, HTML, Excel, PowerPoint, etc.) with which you are capable.
- List specific programming languages
- You may even want to use italicized sub-categories:
- Systems:
- Applications:
- Programming Languages:
- Languages:
- List languages in which you are proficient or conversational and indicate your level of ability ("basic conversational ability," "proficiency," "near-fluency," "fluency") or the number of years of college-level study.
- Laboratory skills:
- If you are applying for scientific or laboratory positions, you may want to create a list of your lab skills. A biology major student might break those skills down into sub-categories such as "histology," "cell culture," and "staining." Of course, the sub-categories and skills mentioned should be relevant to the particular job.
- Always check your skills list with a professor or mentor, unless you have significant professional experience in that career field.
- Section 7: References
- Don't write "References Available on Request" on your resume.

- Do create a references list as soon as you can and have it available, in case an employer asks for references.

Step 5: Format your resume.

- Direct the employer's eye to the most important information: (remember, 10-30 seconds)
  1. Leave plenty of white space on your resume - don't make your resume look crowded.
  2. Emphasize job titles by boldfacing them (except where the name of a prestigious organization you have worked for will grab their attention first).
  3. Place the most important information closer to the top of your resume. (For example, if you are a student and your paid work has been fairly mundane, but you have great computer skills or excellent extracurricular leadership experience, then put the skills or the extracurriculars near the top of your resume.)
  4. Where appropriate, descriptive category headings can attract an employers attention (for example, "Counseling and Tutoring Experience" or "Leadership Experience" instead of just "Experience").
  5. Leave blank space between the separate sections and items on your resume.
- Other formatting details:
- Condense to one page. Exceptions: two-page resumes for nursing, for education and for those alumni who have over two years of experience in that field (however, before going with a two-page resume, check with others in your career field).
- Center and balance your resume on the page, leaving approximately 1 inch margins.
- Design your resume for easy skimming: emphasize by boldfacing, capitalizing and italicizing.
- Use 8 1/2" x 11" white, off-white or very light-gray bond paper. Do not use colored paper.
- Proofread carefully and have others review your final draft.

V. General Resume "Don'ts"

- Include information for leaving a job
- Letters of recommendation
- Race, religion, age, sexual orientation
- Starting date (should be included in the cover letter)
- Photographs
- Inflated jargon
- Use "I"
- Use clichéd adjectives like "dynamic" or "self-starting"; use detailed descriptions of accomplishments to convince employer;
- Just use job duties—prove what you have done
- Send a resume without a cover letter
- Use a resume wizard or place your resume in a table
- Use elaborate fonts (Arial or Times New Roman will suffice)
- Avoid unnecessary personal information such as marital status and date of birth.

VI. General Resume Do's

- Use consistent format and alignment
- Keep in plain text
- Vary sentence structure to avoid bored